

Forecast OS Guide

How to set up and run the Forecast OS workbook, tab by tab.

Resource ID: OPS-02 · Version 2.1 · August 13, 2026

WHO IT'S FOR

Founders using the Forecast OS Workbook (OPS-01).

WHEN TO USE IT

At setup, then at each monthly forecast refresh.

WHAT IT PRODUCES

A correctly configured, maintained forecast with scenario views.

NEXT STEP INSIDE THE ECOSYSTEM

Pair with the Forecast OS Workbook (OPS-01) and refresh monthly. When the forecast needs to drive decisions — pricing, hiring, funding — bring it into a VGP advisory session or a Growth OS dashboard build.

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THE BRAND BLUEPRINT · Powered by Value Growth Partners · Growth OS

Brand Blueprint Forecast OS Template Specification

Version 1 / Shell architecture for VGP founder workbooks

This specification defines the workbook architecture, design principles, tab sequence, data model, user workflow, and future integration hooks for the Brand Blueprint forecasting system. It is intended to become the standard template used across VGP consulting clients, mentorship clients, accelerator cohorts, and founder operating reviews.

1. Design intent

The workbook is designed to function as a founder operating system rather than a static spreadsheet. It should be teachable to non-finance founders, structurally strong enough for investor and lender use, and modular enough to support increasingly automated data flows over time.

The design solves four recurring problems observed in earlier client models: (1) mix-driven forecasts that hide SKU and account reality, (2) revenue views that do not explain channel economics, (3) cash planning that confuses revenue with cash timing, and (4) founder tools that are hard to teach, hard to refresh, or too fragile to reuse.

The template therefore separates source systems, economic channels, and accounts; standardizes actuals in a normalized sales fact table; preserves a monthly forecast plan by account and SKU; and carries those data through price waterfall, P&L, cash flow, inventory, and investor-facing tabs.

2. Core design principles

- Source-specific raw tabs feed one normalized Sales Fact table.
- Source system, economic channel, and account are separate fields and should never be treated as interchangeable.
- Price and channel economics are reviewed before volume assumptions are trusted.
- Actuals are captured at transaction-line level where practical; forecast is maintained at the lowest sustainable planning level, usually month × account × SKU.
- Weekly cadence matters for operations and cash, but the forecast itself should remain manageable and not force founders into unmanageable weekly planning.
- Validation tabs are part of the operating model, not an afterthought.
- The workbook must teach itself through numbered tabs, color logic, and plain-English guidance.
- The model is a decision tool, not a claim of perfect prediction.

3. Workbook color and numbering logic

The final workbook should guide a founder through a logical sequence. The numbering scheme and visual hierarchy are therefore part of the product.

Range	Color family	Meaning
00-03	Gray / guidance	How to use the workbook, KPI guide, and error help
10-14	Navy / setup	Master data, assumptions, and mapping rules
20-23	Yellow / raw input	Paste-only source imports
30-34	Orange / control	Validation, duplicates, and reconciliation
40-46	Light blue / engine	Actuals, forecast, and economic analysis
50-54	Green / finance	P&L, cash flow, inventory, PO funding, account profitability
60-63	Purple / executive	Founder, investor, and management dashboards
70-71	Gray / governance	Action tracking and source log

4. Standard user workflow

1. Complete company setup, SKU Master, Account Master, and Channel Terms.
2. Document mapping logic before raw imports begin.
3. Paste source exports into the raw tabs or normalize directly into Sales Fact when needed.
4. Review import status, unmapped items, duplicates, and reconciliation tabs until checks clear.
5. Update future forecast rows in Forecast Plan.
6. Review Forecast Summary, P&L, Weekly Cash Flow, Inventory Reorder, and Account Profitability.
7. Use Founder Dashboard, Investor Snapshot, and Operating Summary for discussion and sharing.
8. End meetings in the Data Needed Action Tracker and Sources & Assumption Log.

5. Data model

The normalized Sales Fact structure is the spine of the model. Every source should ultimately map into the following conceptual fields: transaction date, month, week start, source system, source reference, economic channel, account name, parent account, raw SKU, standard SKU, units, unit price, gross sales, discounts/credits, net sales, unit cost, COGS, gross margin dollars, margin percent, status, include flag, notes, unique key, and duplicate flag.

This architecture allows the workbook to support Shopify-driven DTC actuals, QuickBooks-driven wholesale actuals, marketplace exports, and manual adjustments without breaking the downstream model structure.

6. Tab-by-tab specification

Tab	Type	Specification summary
00_Start Here	Purpose	Intro page, orientation, and founder-friendly framing of what the workbook is and is not.
01_How to Refresh	Purpose	Weekly / monthly workflow reference used in training and support.
02_KPI Guide	Purpose	Plain-English coaching guide to the most important measures.
03_Common Errors	Purpose	Troubleshooting reference to reduce avoidable founder confusion.
10_Company Setup	Inputs	Model year, start date, beginning cash, closed-actual-month cutoff, target gross margin, average monthly OpEx, lead time override, safety stock override, platform notes.
11_SKU Master	Inputs	All active SKUs with pricing, cost, inventory, lead time, case pack, MOQ, and notes.
12_Account Master	Inputs	Accounts, parent accounts, default source system, default economic channel, payment terms, fee assumptions, key-account flag.
13_Channel Terms	Inputs	Channel-level economics including margins, fees, freight, trade, chargebacks, payment timing, deposit assumptions.
14_Source & Mapping Rules	Inputs	Mapping tables that translate raw source labels into standard source system, channel, SKU, and account definitions.

Tab	Type	Specification summary
20_Raw Shopify	Raw input	Paste native Shopify order export without formulas.
21_Raw NonShopify Sales	Raw input	Paste QuickBooks/accounting export or manual wholesale/distributor sales.
22_Raw Marketplace Optional	Raw input	Optional marketplace feed when not already represented in Shopify.
23_Raw Adjustments	Raw input	Returns, write-offs, replacements, samples, and credits.
30_Import Status	Control	Top-line row-count and obvious-gap check.
31_Unmapped SKUs	Control	SKU mapping exception view.
32_Unmapped Accounts	Control	Account mapping exception view.
33_Duplicate Check	Control	Duplicate transaction review.
34_Reconciliation Checks	Control	Core structural checks tying actuals, forecast, P&L, cash flow, and inventory.
40_Sales Fact Clean	Engine	Normalized actuals table used by the entire model.
41_Monthly Actuals	Engine	Monthly actual rollup by channel.
42_Weekly Actuals	Engine	Weekly actual rollup for cadence and quick checks.
43_Forecast Plan	Engine	Future plan by month, account, channel, and SKU.
44_Forecast Summary	Engine	Monthly forecast summary by channel.
45_Price Waterfall	Analysis	Per-unit channel economics and contribution view.
46_Key Account Waterfall	Analysis	Selected-account profitability and terms review.
50_P&L	Finance	Monthly actual + forecast P&L

Tab	Type	Specification summary
		with detailed OpEx rows.
51_Weekly Cash Flow	Finance	Weekly cash roll-forward linked to revenue, COGS, OpEx, PO cash needs, and adjustments.
52_Inventory Reorder	Finance / operations	SKU-level reorder logic based on demand, lead time, and safety stock.
53_PO Funding Planner	Finance / operations	Funding-gap tool for large orders that require cash before payment arrives.
54_Account Profitability	Finance / analysis	Forecast profitability by account.
60_Founder Dashboard	Executive	Founder-facing operating summary.
61_Account Dashboard	Executive	Selected-account lens for customer review.
62_Investor Snapshot	Executive	Investor / lender summary.
63_Operating Summary	Executive	Weekly / monthly management dashboard.
70_Data Needed Action Tracker	Governance	Meeting action list and open-data tracker.
71_Sources & Assumption Log	Governance	Source log for assumptions, proxies, and updates.
99_Lists	Support	Reference lists used by validations and standard labels.

7. Required calculations

- Monthly Actuals must summarize units, net sales, COGS, gross margin dollars, and gross margin percent by channel.
- Forecast Plan must calculate gross sales, net sales, COGS, gross margin dollars, and gross margin percent from unit inputs and SKU Master defaults.
- Forecast Summary must roll Forecast Plan to month × channel views.
- P&L must switch closed months to actuals using the closed-actual-month input and use forecast for open months.

- Weekly Cash Flow must roll beginning cash to ending cash every row and allocate monthly values across weeks.
- Inventory Reorder must compute weeks of cover, reorder point, reorder-needed flag, suggested PO quantity, and estimated PO value.
- Account Profitability must summarize forecast volume and margin by account.
- Reconciliation Checks must confirm that actuals, forecast, and P&L aggregates tie within tolerance.

8. Teaching features required in every founder version

The workbook must remain self-explanatory when sent without live commentary. Every founder-facing version should preserve the following elements:

- Clear title/purpose block at the top of each tab
- Yellow input areas only where editing is intended
- KPI Guide with plain-English definitions
- Common Errors sheet with issue code, meaning, and fix path
- Data Needed Action Tracker for meeting follow-up
- Sources & Assumption Log so proxies are visible and defensible

9. Future automation roadmap

The shell is intentionally workbook-first, but it is designed to sit inside a broader VGP operating system. The following integrations should be considered phase-two or phase-three enhancements rather than prerequisites for daily use:

- Google Form intake populating a client record and copying a founder workbook template
- Google Drive folder creation and founder dashboard setup
- Calendly booking triggers creating prep docs and meeting workflows
- Otter meeting summary ingestion into agendas, action trackers, and next-meeting prep
- Shopify / QuickBooks / marketplace exports mapped into raw tabs or normalized automatically
- Automated investor update views and founder-specific monthly research packages

10. Minimum quality-control checklist

- No #REF!, #VALUE!, #NAME?, or #N/A errors on core tabs
- Raw-source data does not double count across Shopify, marketplace, and accounting exports
- Unmapped SKUs and unmapped accounts are resolved or explicitly explained
- Closed actual months are not overwritten by wishful forecasting
- Price waterfall and channel terms are reviewed before high-volume scenarios are trusted
- Inventory and PO funding implications are reviewed before large retailer or distributor commitments are accepted
- Founder Dashboard, Investor Snapshot, and Operating Summary all populate cleanly

11. Suggested next build steps

1. Use the workbook shell as the standard VGP template.

2. Pilot the shell with one or two active founders and record where they still get confused.
3. Refine raw import formats using one real Shopify Orders export and one real QuickBooks / invoice export.
4. Decide which parts of Sales Fact normalization should remain manual versus scripted.
5. Add optional charts and polished print layouts after the structure proves durable in live use.

12. Option A Component Forecasting Extension

Purpose. Option A extends the Brand Blueprint Forecast OS with a reusable component-level planning module. The core OS remains unchanged through tabs 00-72, while tabs 78-85 add bill-of-materials, component catalog, component demand, and component PO planning capability for founders whose products require multi-part production planning.

When to use. Use this extension for beauty, fragrance, food, beverage, wellness, apparel, home goods, and other product businesses where a finished SKU depends on multiple components, vendors, MOQs, lead times, or packaging decisions. For very simple businesses, the extension can remain blank while the core OS still functions.

Core rule. Component planning must be driven by forecast units. Actuals feed the forecast plan; the forecast plan feeds inventory and component demand; component demand feeds PO timing and working-capital planning. Components should not be forecast directly unless they are intentionally decoupled from finished-goods demand.

12.1 Component extension tab sequence

Tab	Type	Specification summary
78_Component Index	Guidance	Navigation sheet explaining how the component extension works and when to use it.
79_Component Module Guide	Guidance	Founder-facing instructions for completing BOM, component catalog, demand review, and PO planning.
80_Component BOM	Inputs	Finished SKU to component mapping, including component quantity per finished unit, UOM, required flag, and notes.
81_Component Catalog	Inputs	Component master list containing vendor, category, lead time, MOQ, unit cost, order increment, source, confirmation status, and notes.
82_Component Demand	Engine	Forecast units multiplied by BOM requirements to estimate weekly or monthly component demand.
83_Component PO Planner	Finance / operations	Planning view that converts gross component demand into net need, suggested PO quantities, estimated PO value, and PO commit dates.
84_Inputs Remaining	Governance	Live meeting checklist of missing costs, vendors, MOQs, lead times, or confirmation items.
85_Vendor Comparison Current	Analysis	Side-by-side comparison of current and prospective vendors, including terms,

		scope, lead times, costs, and decision notes.
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12.2 Required component calculations

- Component demand should equal forecast units multiplied by component quantity per finished unit from the BOM.
- Component PO need should reflect gross demand, on-hand inventory, open POs, safety stock, MOQs, and ordering increments.
- Estimated PO value should calculate from suggested PO quantity and unit cost in the Component Catalog.
- PO commit dates should backsolve from need-by dates using lead time plus any buffer weeks.
- Where unit cost, lead time, or MOQ is unknown, the cell should be visibly flagged as an assumption or missing input rather than hidden.

12.3 Minimum quality-control checks for Option A

- Every forecasted SKU should either have a BOM row or be intentionally marked as excluded from component planning.
- Every component used in the BOM should exist in the Component Catalog.
- No component should have a blank unit of measure.
- Known vendor costs should cite the source in notes or the Sources & Assumption Log.
- Assumed vendor costs should be highlighted and documented until confirmed.
- The PO Planner should not create negative PO quantities.
- Lead-time dates should fall before need-by dates; exceptions should be flagged for review.

12.4 Teaching notes

Founder explanation. The component module answers the operating question: “If this is what we plan to sell, what pieces do we need to buy, from which vendor, by when, and how much cash will that require?” This separates revenue planning from production readiness and prevents founders from accepting channel opportunities without understanding component timing and working-capital pressure.

The Option A extension should be included in the standard Forecast OS shell as a blank but available module. Consultants can hide it for service businesses or keep it visible for product businesses.

12.5 Relationship to existing OS tabs

OS Tab	Connects To	Purpose
43_Forecast Plan	82_Component Demand	Finished units by SKU/account/month drive component requirements.
11_SKU Master	80_Component BOM	SKU list defines the finished goods that require component mapping.
13_Channel Terms	83_Component PO Planner	Customer timing and payment terms affect working-capital pressure.
51_Weekly Cash Flow	83_Component PO Planner	PO cash needs should flow into weekly cash planning.
52_Inventory Reorder	83_Component PO Planner	Finished-goods reorder timing should be reconciled to

		component PO timing.
70_Data Needed Tracker	84_Inputs Remaining	Missing inputs become live action items.
71_Sources	81_Component Catalog	Vendor quotes, public assumptions, and source documents are logged.